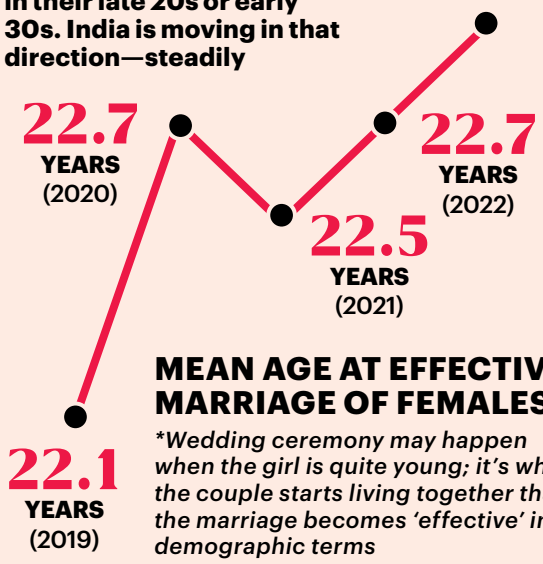
THE RISING AGE OF MARRIAGE

Women in high-income countries usually marry in their late 20s or early 30s. India is moving in that direction—steadily



MEAN AGE AT EFFECTIVE MARRIAGE OF FEMALES*

**Wedding ceremony may happen when the girl is quite young; it's when the couple starts living together that the marriage becomes 'effective' in demographic terms*

The Rural-Urban Divide

Rural	22.4
Urban	24.3

Mean age at effective marriage of females (in years)

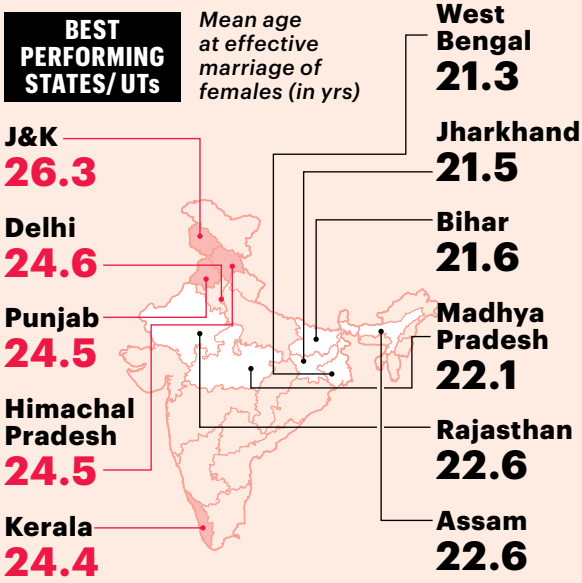
Regional Variations

Smaller states and UTs lead the way, as women there marry later than in much of the Hindi heartland and eastern states

BEST PERFORMING STATES/ UTs

Mean age at effective marriage of females (in yrs)

WORST PERFORMING STATES/ UTs

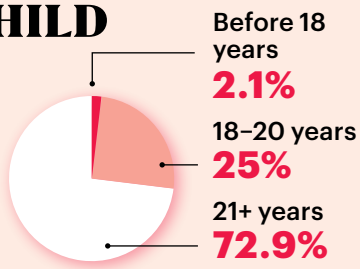


Note: Goa, smaller northeastern states and UTs other than Delhi and J&K have not been included

INDIA'S CHILD BRIDES

About one in 50 women in India is still married off before she turns 18

Age at effective marriage of females



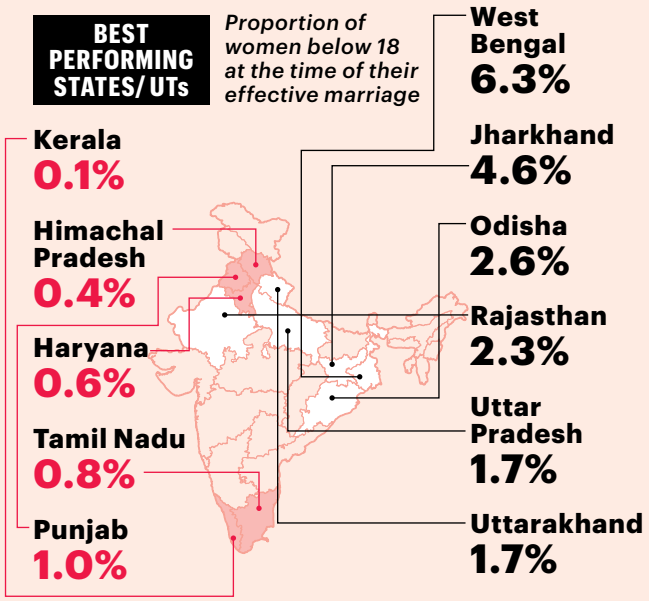
Kerala Leads Change

...aided by near-universal female literacy, robust local governance and strong community vigilance

BEST PERFORMING STATES/ UTs

Proportion of women below 18 at the time of their effective marriage

WORST PERFORMING STATES/ UTs



THE CHALLENGE AHEAD

↘ **Uneven progress:** Five states—UP, Bihar, West Bengal, Maharashtra and MP—account for over half of all child marriages, underscoring the need for sharper, localised interventions

↘ **Emerging health priorities:** With more births now occurring among women aged 28–35, India's health systems must expand fertility care and pre-natal screening for older mothers

↘ **Beyond the law:** Raising women's marriage age to 21 remains debatable. Real progress needs investments in girls' education, health and safety to empower them to delay marriage by choice

"Boosting girl education, giving them market-ready skills and ensuring job access is far more effective than simply raising the legal age of marriage"

POONAM MUTTREJA
Executive Director, Population Foundation of India